in intellectual influence is even more unsettling than the unequal distribution of wealth—unsettling because, unlike the income gap, no social policy can eliminate it. Communism could conceal or compress income discrepancies, but it could not eliminate the superstar system in intellectual life.

It has even been shown, by Michael Marmot of the Whitehall Studies, that those at the top of the pecking order live longer, even when adjusting for disease. Marmot's impressive project shows how social rank alone can affect longevity. It was calculated that actors who win an Oscar tend to live on average about five years longer than their peers who don't. People live longer in societies that have flatter social gradients. Winners kill their peers as those in a steep social gradient live shorter lives, regardless of their economic condition.

I do not know how to remedy this (except through religious beliefs). Is insurance against your peers' demoralizing success possible? Should the Nobel Prize be banned? Granted the Nobel medal in economics has not been good for society or knowledge, but even those rewarded for *real* contributions in medicine and physics too rapidly displace others from our consciousness, and steal longevity away from them. Extremistan is here to stay, so we have to live with it, and find the tricks that make it more palatable.

* These scalable laws were already discussed in the scriptures: "For onto everyone that hath shall be given, and he shall have abundance; but from him that hath not shall be taken away even that which he hath." Matthew (Matthew 25:29, King James Version).

* Much of the perception of the importance of precocity in the career of researchers can be owed to the misunderstanding of the perverse role of this effect, especially when reinforced by bias. Enough counterexamples, even in fields like mathematics meant to be purely a "young man's game," illustrate the age fallacy: simply, it is necessary to be successful early, and even very early at that.

* The Web's bottom-up feature is also making book reviewers more accountable. While writers were helpless and vulnerable to the arbitrariness of book reviews, which can distort their messages and, thanks to the confirmation bias, expose small irrelevant weak points in their text, they now have a much stronger hand. In place of the moaning letter to the editor, they can simply post their review of a review on the Web. If attacked ad hominem, they can reply ad hominem and go directly after the credibility of the reviewer, making sure that their statement shows rapidly in an Internet search or on Wikipedia, the bottom-up encyclopedia.

* As if we did not have enough problems, banks are now more vulnerable to the Black Swan and the ludic fallacy than ever before with "scientists" among their staff taking care of exposures. The giant firm J. P. Morgan put the entire world at risk by introducing in the nineties RiskMetrics, a phony method aiming at managing people's risks, causing the generalized use of the ludic fallacy, and bringing Dr. Johns into power in place of the skeptical Fat Tonys. (A related method called "Value-at-Risk," which relies on the quantitative measurement of risk, has been spreading.) Likewise, the government-sponsored institution Fanny Mae, when I look at their risks, seems to be sitting on a barrel of dynamite, vulnerable to the slightest hiccup. But not to worry: their large staff of scientists deemed these events "unlikely."